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The web platform got really good while you weren't looking.

Modern HTML & CSS

56 features you're not using (but should be)

Built-in elements, selectors, and one-liners that replace entire libraries, kill old hacks, and delete JavaScript you no longer need to write. Every one is copy-paste ready.

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WHAT'S INSIDE

56 things the browser already does for you

No frameworks, no dependencies, just modern HTML and CSS that shipped in every major browser while the internet was busy arguing about JavaScript. Eight short chapters:

01 **Native UI, Zero JavaScript** #01–07

02 **Forms That Don't Suck** #08–15

03 **Selectors With Superpowers** #16–22

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How to use this guide: skim the chapter that matches what you're building, copy the snippet, and ship it. Anything tagged *Newer: check support* is worth a quick look at caniuse.com before you rely on it in production.

01 Native UI, Zero JavaScript

The browser ships components you keep reaching for a library to build.

---

01 The <dialog> element

WIDELY SUPPORTED

A real modal with a backdrop, focus trapping, and Esc-to-close. No library required.

```
<dialog id="modal">
  <form method="dialog">
    <p>Delete this item?</p>
    <button value="cancel">Cancel</button>
    <button value="confirm">Delete</button>
  </form>
</dialog>

<button onclick="modal.showModal()">Open</button>
```

WHY showModal() traps focus and dims the page; method="dialog" closes it and reports which button was pressed. Style the dim layer with ::backdrop.

02 <details> & <summary>

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Accordions and “read more” toggles with built-in keyboard support and zero JS.

```
<details name="faq">
  <summary>What's included?</summary>
  <p>Everything you need, nothing you don't.</p>
</details>
```

WHY Add the open attribute to expand by default. Give several the same name and they behave as an exclusive accordion.

03 The Popover API

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Menus, tooltips, and toasts that float on top of everything and dismiss on outside-click, declaratively.

```
<button popovertarget="menu">Menu</button>

<div id="menu" popover>
  <a href="/profile">Profile</a>
  <a href="/logout">Log out</a>
</div>
```

WHY popover gives you top-layer stacking and light-dismiss for free, with no z-index wars or click-outside listeners.

04 <datalist> autocomplete

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Native autocomplete suggestions on any text input.

```
<input list="frameworks" name="framework">
<datalist id="frameworks">
  <option value="React">
  <option value="Vue">
  <option value="Svelte">
</datalist>
```

WHY Users can still type anything. The list is only suggestions. Perfect for “search or pick one.”

05 <progress> & <meter>

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Semantic progress bars and gauges that assistive tech actually understands.

```
<progress value="70" max="100">70%</progress>

<meter value="0.8" low="0.3" high="0.7">80%</meter>
```

WHY <progress> is for task completion; <meter> shows a value in a known range (disk space, score) and recolors itself across the thresholds.

06 The :target selector

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Tabs, lightboxes, and “jump” panels driven entirely by the URL hash.

```
.panel { display: none; }
.panel:target { display: block; }
```

WHY Clicking a link to #panel-2 reveals it, with no JavaScript, and the state lives in a shareable URL.

07 scroll-behavior: smooth

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Smooth-scroll anchor links and “back to top” in a single line.

```
html {
  scroll-behavior: smooth;
}
```

WHY Deletes a whole JavaScript snippet. Wrap it in prefers-reduced-motion to respect people who get motion sick.

02 Forms That Don’t Suck

Tiny attributes that make forms feel native, especially on phones.

08 inputmode

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Show the right on-screen keyboard without changing the input’s type or validation.

```
<input type="text" inputmode="numeric">
<input type="text" inputmode="decimal">
```

WHY Ideal for OTP codes, quantities, and prices where type="number" adds unwanted spinners and locale quirks.

09 enterkeyhint

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Relabel the mobile keyboard’s Enter key to match the action.

```
<input enterkeyhint="search">
<input enterkeyhint="send">
<input enterkeyhint="go">
```

WHY A one-attribute detail that makes your form feel like a real app on phones.

10 autocomplete tokens

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Let browsers and password managers autofill the right value, including SMS one-time codes.

```
<input autocomplete="email">
<input autocomplete="new-password">
<input autocomplete="one-time-code">
```

WHY one-time-code surfaces the OTP from a text message right above the keyboard on iOS. Huge UX win for almost no work.

11 accept & capture

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Filter file types and open the camera directly on mobile.

```
<input type="file" accept="image/*" capture="environment">
```

WHY capture="environment" opens the rear camera; "user" opens the selfie cam. accept limits the picker to images.

12 Built-in validation

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Required fields, patterns, and ranges validated by the browser before you write any JS.

```
<input type="email" required>
<input pattern="[0-9]{4}" title="4 digits">
<input type="number" min="1" max="10" step="1">
```

WHY Free, accessible error messaging. Layer your own UI on top with the Constraint Validation API when you need to.

13 accent-color

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Theme checkboxes, radios, range sliders, and progress bars to your brand in one line.

```
:root {
  accent-color: #7c3aed;
}
```

WHY No more rebuilding native controls from scratch just to change their color.

14 field-sizing: content

NEWER: CHECK SUPPORT

Inputs and textareas that grow and shrink to fit their content automatically.

```
textarea {
  field-sizing: content;
}
```

WHY Retires the classic “auto-resize the textarea” JavaScript hack entirely.

15 The input types you forgot

WIDELY SUPPORTED

The browser already ships polished pickers for dates, colors, ranges, and search.

```
<input type="date">
<input type="color">
<input type="range" min="0" max="100">
<input type="search">
```

WHY Free native UI, validation, and accessibility, with the best payoff on mobile.

03 Selectors With Superpowers

Modern CSS selectors that replace whole piles of JavaScript class-toggling.

---

16 The :has() parent selector

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Style an element based on what it contains or what comes after it. The selector we waited a decade for.

```
/* a card that contains an image */
.card:has(img) { padding: 0; }

/* a label whose input is checked */
label:has(:checked) { font-weight: 700; }
```

WHY Replaces countless “add a class with JS when X happens” patterns with pure CSS.

17 :is()

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Collapse long, repetitive selector lists into one.

```
/* instead of: article h1, article h2, article h3 */
article :is(h1, h2, h3) {
  line-height: 1.2;
}
```

WHY Far less repetition. Note it adopts the specificity of its most specific argument.

18 :where()

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Exactly like :is(), but with zero specificity.

```
:where(ul, ol) {
  margin: 0;
  padding: 0;
}
```

WHY Perfect for resets and defaults you want to be trivially easy to override later.

19 :focus-visible

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Show focus rings for keyboard users without flashing them on every mouse click.

```
button:focus-visible {
  outline: 2px solid #7c3aed;
}
```

WHY Solves the “ugly outline on click” complaint the right way. Don’t just delete outlines and break keyboard access.

20 :focus-within

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Style a container while any element inside it has focus.

```
.search:focus-within {
  box-shadow: 0 0 0 2px #7c3aed;
}
```

WHY Highlight an entire search bar when the user focuses the input inside it.

21 :nth-child(... of S)

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Select the nth element among only the ones matching a selector.

```
/* every 2nd row that is .active */
li:nth-child(2n of .active) {
  background: #f1f5f9;
}
```

WHY Counting respects your filter instead of every sibling. Striped rows that ignore hidden items, finally.

22 Modern :not()

WIDELY SUPPORTED

:not() now takes a list, so one selector can exclude several things at once.

```
.stack > :not(:last-child) {
  margin-bottom: 1rem;
}
.btn:not(.primary, .danger) {
  background: #e2e8f0;
}
```

WHY Add spacing between items without a trailing-margin cleanup hack.

04 Layout, Finally Made Easy

The features that ended the era of float clears and padding-hack ratios.

23 aspect-ratio

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Lock an element to a ratio without padding-hack wrappers.

```
.video {
  aspect-ratio: 16 / 9;
  width: 100%;
}
```

WHY Reserves space before media loads, which kills layout shift (and your Core Web Vitals score thanks you).

24 gap everywhere

WIDELY SUPPORTED

gap isn't just for grid. It spaces flexbox children too.

```
.toolbar {
  display: flex;
  gap: 1rem;
}
```

WHY No more :last-child margin resets or fragile negative-margin math.

25 Center anything

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Perfect centering on both axes in two lines.

```
.hero {
  display: grid;
  place-items: center;
}
```

WHY The official end of the "how do I center a div" meme.

26 Container queries

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Style a component based on the width of its container, not the viewport.

```
.card-list { container-type: inline-size; }

@container (min-width: 400px) {
  .card { grid-template-columns: 1fr 1fr; }
}
```

WHY Genuinely reusable components that adapt wherever you drop them. The real upgrade over media queries.

27 subgrid

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Let a nested grid line up with its parent's tracks.

```
.card {
  display: grid;
  grid-template-rows: subgrid;
  grid-row: span 3;
}
```

WHY Align headings, bodies, and footers across cards even when their content lengths differ.

28 position: sticky

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Headers and sidebars that stick as you scroll, with no scroll-event listeners.

```
thead th {
  position: sticky;
  top: 0;
}
```

WHY Sticky table headers and section labels with one declaration.

29 Logical properties

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Direction-aware spacing that flips automatically for right-to-left languages.

```
.box {
  margin-inline: auto;
  padding-block: 1rem;
}
```

WHY Write your layout once; it adapts to RTL and vertical writing modes for free.

30 The inset shorthand

WIDELY SUPPORTED

One property for top / right / bottom / left on positioned elements.

```
.overlay {
  position: absolute;
  inset: 0;
}
```

WHY inset: 0 stretches an element to perfectly fill its positioned parent.

31 min(), max(), clamp()

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Responsive sizing math with no media queries.

```
.container { width: min(100%, 65ch); }
h1 { font-size: clamp(1.75rem, 4vw, 3rem); }
```

WHY clamp(min, preferred, max) gives fluid type that never gets too small or too large.

05 Text & Media That Behave

Typographic and image features that used to need JavaScript or a build step.

32 text-wrap: balance

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Even out multi-line headings so no single word dangles alone on the last line.

```
h1, h2, blockquote {
  text-wrap: balance;
}
```

WHY Instantly more polished headlines, with zero extra markup.

33 text-wrap: pretty

NEWER: CHECK SUPPORT

Prevent orphans (a lone last word) in body paragraphs.

```
p {
  text-wrap: pretty;
}
```

WHY Magazine-grade typographic polish for long-form content.

34 Line clamping

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Truncate text to a fixed number of lines with an ellipsis.

```
.excerpt {
  display: -webkit-box;
  -webkit-line-clamp: 3;
  -webkit-box-orient: vertical;
  overflow: hidden;
}
```

WHY Clean, equal-height card previews. The standardized line-clamp property is on its way in.

35 object-fit & object-position

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Crop images to fill a box without squishing them.

```
.avatar {
  width: 80px;
  aspect-ratio: 1;
  object-fit: cover;
  object-position: center;
}
```

WHY Like background-size: cover, but on a real, accessible <img> with alt text.

36 Responsive images done right

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Serve the best size and format for each device, and defer the offscreen ones.

```
<picture>
  <source srcset="hero.avif" type="image/avif">
  <img src="hero.jpg" alt="" loading="lazy" decoding="async">
</picture>
```

WHY loading="lazy" defers offscreen images and AVIF/WebP via <source> can cut image weight dramatically.

06 Color & Theming

Dynamic color and dark mode without a preprocessor or a second stylesheet.

37 CSS custom properties

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Real variables in the browser: themeable, scoped, and updatable live from JavaScript.

```
:root { --brand: #7c3aed; }
.btn { background: var(--brand, #333); }
```

WHY The second value in var() is a fallback used if the variable isn't defined.

38 color-mix()

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Tint, shade, and blend colors directly in CSS, with no Sass functions needed.

```
.btn:hover {
  background: color-mix(in oklch, var(--brand), black 15%);
}
```

WHY Generate hover, active, and disabled states from a single brand color.

39 light-dark()

NEWER: CHECK SUPPORT

Declare a light value and a dark value in one property.

```
:root { color-scheme: light dark; }
body {
  background: light-dark(#fff, #0f172a);
  color: light-dark(#111, #e2e8f0);
}
```

WHY Dark mode without duplicating your whole stylesheet inside a media query.

40 prefers-color-scheme

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Respect the user's OS light/dark preference, including native form controls.

```
:root { color-scheme: light dark; }

@media (prefers-color-scheme: dark) {
  body { background: #0f172a; }
}
```

WHY color-scheme on its own restyles scrollbars, inputs, and checkboxes for dark mode.

41 currentColor

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Reuse an element's text color anywhere: borders, icons, shadows.

```
.icon { fill: currentColor; }
.tag  { border: 1px solid currentColor; }
```

WHY Change the color once and everything referencing currentColor updates with it.

42 @property

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Register typed custom properties so you can animate things CSS normally can't, like gradient angles.

```
@property --angle {
  syntax: "<angle>";
  inherits: false;
  initial-value: 0deg;
}
.card { transition: --angle 0.4s; }
```

WHY Unlocks smooth transitions of gradients and other values browsers couldn't interpolate before.

07 Polish, Motion & UX

The small details that separate a site that works from one that feels expensive.

43 CSS scroll snap

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Carousels and sliders that snap cleanly to each item, in pure CSS.

```
.slider {
  display: flex;
  overflow-x: auto;
  scroll-snap-type: x mandatory;
}
.slide { scroll-snap-align: center; }
```

WHY Smooth, native-feeling carousels with no slider library and no JS.

44 backdrop-filter

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Frosted-glass blur behind an element.

```
.navbar {
  background: rgba(255, 255, 255, 0.6);
  -webkit-backdrop-filter: blur(12px); /* Safari */
  backdrop-filter: blur(12px);
}
```

WHY Keep the -webkit- prefix. Safari still needs it, and without it the blur silently disappears for a big chunk of mobile users.

45 ::selection

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Style the highlight color when people select your text.

```
::selection {
  background: #7c3aed;
  color: #fff;
}
```

WHY A subtle branding touch the vast majority of sites never bother with.

46 caret-color

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Color the blinking text cursor inside inputs.

```
input {
  caret-color: #7c3aed;
}
```

WHY Tiny detail, big “someone actually cared” energy.

47 prefers-reduced-motion

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Turn off animations for people who experience motion sickness.

```
@media (prefers-reduced-motion: reduce) {
  *, *::before, *::after {
    animation-duration: 0.01ms !important;
    transition-duration: 0.01ms !important;
  }
}
```

WHY An accessibility must-have, and trivial to drop into any project.

48 Styled scrollbars

NEWER: CHECK SUPPORT

Thin, on-brand scrollbars, plus reserved gutter space to stop layout jumps.

```
html {
  scrollbar-gutter: stable;
  scrollbar-width: thin;
  scrollbar-color: #7c3aed transparent;
}
```

WHY scrollbar-gutter reserves the space so content doesn't shift. The standard color/width landed in browsers only recently and Safari is still patchy, so pair with ::-webkit-scrollbar for full control.

49 View Transitions

NEWER: CHECK SUPPORT

Animate between states or pages with a few lines instead of a motion library.

```
document.startViewTransition(() => {
  updateTheDOM();
});
```

WHY Built-in crossfades and shared-element morphs. Add @view-transition { navigation: auto; } for cross-page transitions.

50 :user-valid / :user-invalid

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Validation styles that only appear after the user has actually interacted with a field.

```
input:user-invalid { border-color: #ef4444; }
input:user-valid   { border-color: #22c55e; }
```

WHY No more red error states screaming at people before they've typed a single character.

08 Bonus: Pro Performance Touches

Six more that quietly make your sites faster and your CSS saner.

---

51 content-visibility: auto

NEWER: CHECK SUPPORT

Skip rendering offscreen content for big performance wins on long pages.

```
.section {
  content-visibility: auto;
  contain-intrinsic-size: auto 500px;
}
```

WHY The browser skips layout and paint for what isn't visible yet, then renders it as you scroll.

52 @supports

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Feature-detect in CSS and provide a graceful fallback.

```
@supports (field-sizing: content) {
  textarea { field-sizing: content; }
}
```

WHY Ship cutting-edge CSS safely. Older browsers simply skip the block.

53 @layer (cascade layers)

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Control which styles win without specificity wars or !important.

```
@layer reset, base, components, utilities;
```

WHY Later layers beat earlier ones regardless of specificity, a lifesaver in large codebases.

54 The inert attribute

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Disable a whole subtree: no clicks, no focus, hidden from assistive tech.

```
<main inert>… background content …</main>
```

WHY Exactly what you want for the page behind an open custom modal.

55 The download attribute

WIDELY SUPPORTED

Make a link download a file (and rename it) instead of navigating to it.

```
<a href="/report.pdf" download="2026-report.pdf">Download</a>
```

WHY No special server headers needed for same-origin files.

56 hidden=”until-found”

NEWER: CHECK SUPPORT

Hide content that’s still findable by in-page search and “scroll to text” links.

```
<p hidden="until-found">Collapsed FAQ answer…</p>
```

WHY The browser automatically reveals it and scrolls to it when a match is found.

STAY IN TOUCH

Thanks for reading.
Let’s stay connected.

I share practical HTML, CSS, and JavaScript tips every week. Come say hi, ask a question, or just follow along wherever you already hang out.

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